

Part 9: Linked Missions And End Goals

9.1 Linked Missions

As mentioned in Part One, *Zona Alfa* is story-centered. Connected, narrative games tend to get players involved and help them stay focused. The Three-Act sequence is ideal to create an escalating sense of tension and purpose. Casualties, experience, Salvage all carry over as part of a larger, over-arching quest. When making a set of linked missions, Mission Objectives should relate, directly or obliquely, to that bigger goal, and ideally, the rewards and the danger should ratchet up each mission too, all to culminate in a final battle that is the most dangerous and the most rewarding.

If you get stuck, here are some Mission prompts. Roll a D6 for each column and use the results to create a scenario. Tweak and bend as needed. For example, if you roll *Eliminate/Sabotage* – *Supplies* – *Old Factory*, both sides could vie for the chance not simply to destroy select items in a larger cache, but complete the objective by poisoning the food or mixing defective ammo in with the boxes. Or, if the Crews are Enemies, you might task one side with demolition and the other with preventing their destruction. This is your chance to make a story and invent a motive for a follow-up mission.

Mission Table			
D6 Roll	Action	Item	Location
1	Retrieve/Deliver	Data Recorder	Disabled Vehicle Convoy
2	Defend/Protect	Downed Aerial Drone	Remote Outpost
3	Eliminate/Sabotage	Supplies	Abandoned Village
4	Investigate/Repair	V.I.P.	Old Factory
5	Locate/Hunt	Vital Component	Military Bunker
6	Escort/Steal	Mutant	Ruined City

Example

The Lost Military Convoy

Rumor has it there is an abandoned military convoy that has a supply of weapons, armor, and decent gear. Everyone knows someone who heard it's on a back road in the North part of the Zone, near a village with a well. Sounds great except 'Up North' and 'village with a well' are kind of vague. No one has been able to nail down any definite information about where these Army trucks are located.

Now the Zone churns out rumors like a swamp in August breeds mosquitoes, and they're twice as annoying. But this one just won't die. So perhaps there's some truth to it. The only one who seemed to have his teeth in this tale was Big Ears Boris, and he's overdue from a supply run to some scientists in a Blue area east of here.

Mission One: Get Big Ears' PDA

Area: Abandoned Village TL 1 (2 Hot Spots). Objective: Locate and Search Big Ears' corpse. His PDA has clues about Convoy's whereabouts.

Mission Two: Fill 'Er Up

Area: Fuel Depot/Gas Station. TL 1 (2 Hot Spots) Objective: The Convoy does indeed exist but there's too much to carry away. The smart thing to do is pack it all in one of the vehicles and drive everything out. But to do that, you'll need a Wrench to fix up a truck, and some petrol. You can hire a Wrench at the Stalls, but there's only one place in the area where you can get petrol without letting everyone else know what you're up to, so off you go to that old gas station.

Mission Three: Road Rage

Area: Wooded region with single road down the middle and several vehicles. TL 2 (4 Hot Spots) Objective: Clear the Area and get a truck running (Skill Check, Difficulty 2). Don't forget the petrol.

9.2 End Goals: The 10,000 Ruble Plan and Other Retirement Options

"Have SMART ambitions", is that not what your life coach told you? No? Well then let me extol the benefits of having Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Realistic, and Timely goals. Especially if you're risking the Zone. You have to know when to cut your losses and get out with your hide in one piece.

Individual *Zona Alfa* games have specific Mission Objectives and Turn Limits to put an edge and end on the action. In the same way, individual crews should have a retirement goal in mind. The idea here is to minimize uneven matches between highly experienced, tooled up crews, and a gaggle of newbs clutching surplus AK-47s.

The first and simplest option is to set up a retirement account. For that, 10,000 is the magic number.

At the end of every mission, calculate the value of your Salvage, replace any spent Gear, buy some new Equipment or perhaps improvements for your crew, but always remember to set some money aside for your retirement.

Track your savings on your team roster, tallying up after each mission. Once your retirement fund reaches 10,000, that crew can bow out. You've pressed your luck, you've spit in Death's face one too many times and now it's time to step back and let some other no-brain, weasel-eyed, itchy-trigger finger newb have a go. It's time to kick back at the Black Sea with vodka, caviar, and half a dozen Russian lingerie models.

Other Options

If a Retirement Fund is too simple, imagine your Crew has been contracted to retrieve 12 Zone Artifacts of any type. Everything else found along the way is yours to keep and do with what you will. This job could be from a Scientific Organization, a Consortium of Investors, or an Ultra-Wealthy Private Collector. Of course, rival Artifact Hunters will be angling to fill the same order before your crew.

It may be possible that a secretive Government faction has decided the Zone is too mysterious, too dangerous, too unpredictable to be allowed to exist. These politicians believe it must be destroyed and so have arranged to have a 20-megaton nuclear warhead placed into the center of the Zone. This device will be detonated remotely following a 6-week, increasingly alarmist PR media blitz that investigates the area's 'inherent instability and threat to the region.' Of course, the detonation would be purely coincidental and would serve only to cement the group's legitimacy and power.

Structure a campaign where you and your crew must find the means and the men to disarm the device. But be aware this faction has sent in private security teams to ensure their plan is successful. Alternatively, you could be the ones gathering components, smuggling the device deep into the center, fending off attacks by those who want to stop you!

Perhaps your Crew specializes in mutant hunting expeditions or is part of a research Institute charged with data and sample collection from every Threat Level in the Zone, in every region, North, South, East, and West. This means 12 separate excursions, 13 if they demand you travel to the Center. (That's a lucky number, right?)

Part 10: Introductory Zone Run – Red Gypsy 3

'Red Gypsy 3' is an introductory set of three linked missions designed to ease you and your new crew into the Zone.

It starts with a cake walk: all you have to do is retrieve a piece of lost luggage. Actually, it's a briefcase in a disabled BTR in a deserted village on the edge of the Zone but still easy, right?

Next is a stroll through the woods. Sure, it's in a Threat Level 1 area, but a little exercise never hurt anyone.

Lastly you and your comrades arrive at a deserted town a bit deeper in the Yellow Zone, (TL 2) hunting for the hidden entrance to an old military cache. You've heard there's at least one other crew on the trail of this same prize, plus God knows what else is lurking in the area, but no risk, no rewards, eh?

Good hunting, comrade.

Game One: The Crossroads at Blyats

Rumor has it, less than nine weeks after the first Incident, a military detachment on the edge of the Zone was attacked a night by a huge swarm of mutants. Up to that time, no one had ever seen creatures like that, let alone so many. Anyway, the soldiers panicked and bolted.

Their little convoy almost made it out too, but they were overrun practically in sight of the Cordon in a small, one-cov village called Blyatsk.

Now, this was early one and no one had any idea what the Zone was or what was going on, and a few dozen deaths became just another statistic. Well it turns out those troops been guarding one of the 'Gypsy' supply caches.

Who knows if it's true, but damned if there isn't a blown BTR at the cross roads at Blyatsk. Right there, out in the open.

Anyway, a guy knows a guy who said he heard someone in a bar say there was a military attaché case in the rusty transport with the location of Red Gypsy 3 – the third of the military stashes.

All we have to do is get there, rummage inside the old rust bucket and find the case – if it's there. If we hurry, we can get back before dark.

Table Size

4' x 4'

Threat Level

Zero – White. Just inside the Cordon. One Mission Objective. No additional Salvage, no Hot Spots.

Terrain

Two roads crossing in roughly the center of the mission area. Minimum of four structures clustered around the middle, plus stands of trees, hedges, fences, water towers, and any other appropriate scatter terrain. Some type of military vehicle (a jeep, truck, APC...) should be placed in the crossroads in the center of game area

Suggested Crew Experience

Starter Crew with Veteran Crew Leader.

Deployment Zones

Crews set up in opposite corners inside a 6" x 6" area.

Turn Limit

Seven.

Zone Hostiles

Two Packs of Feral Dogs already deployed at random in one of the four structures. And the Zombified Crew of military vehicle (Four Zombies – Hardened – 2 Actions per Activation). Use standard Zone Hostile deployment rules.

Salvage

Successful Search Action of vehicle after the area is cleared yields a moldy military-issue attaché case, two regular hand grenades, and one roll on the Basic Equipment Table (see page 32).

Game Two: Walk in the Chernya Woods

The stinking Rotters came out of nowhere... You never knew something that decayed could move so fast. So, you yanked a moldy old leather briefcase from under a seat, swept up a handful of stuff from an open gear bin and ran for it. You never knew you could move that fast either.

Most of the papers were ruined, but one at the very bottom had the heading 'RED GYPSY 3' on it in big block print. And below there was a list of rifles, pistols, a column of 'Special Weapons'. Cases of ammo, boxes of grenades... All of it typed up neat as could be. If half this stuff is there, we'll be rich.

Trouble is that same piece of paper mentioned a keycard – a one-of-a-kind special keycard that's needed to unlock the steel door that leads to the stash. And that's a problem.

Yuri mentioned the last guy who passed through Blyatsk was new to the Zone: some thug named Big Nikolai. Apparently, he got tired of being a junior *Bratva* bull in Moscow and decided he wanted a bigger slice of the pie. So, he grabbed a handful of his boys and bribed his way past the Cordon guards. Word is he's camped in the Chernya Woods.

You're not big on that forest, or chatting up Bandits for that matter, but it's the only lead you've got right now.

Guess it's time for a walk in the woods.

Table Size

4' x 4'

Threat Level

One – Blue. One Mission Objective. Two Hot Spots.

Terrain

The mission area is a wooded location that's bisected by a dirt trail. This trail runs from one corner of the mission area to the lower, opposite corner and divides the game table into two triangle-shaped sections. In the center of the mission area, on the trail, is a large clearing with four makeshift barriers: stacked rubbish, shrubs, short sections of broken fence or stone walls. This is the Mission Objective.

There are two smaller clearings, one in the middle of each of the two triangular halves of the mission area. These are not on the dirt trail. These are the two secondary Hot Spots.

You'll need plenty of stands of trees for this one. The floor of the Chernya Woods is relatively clear of undergrowth and debris.

Suggested Crew Experience

Starter Crew with Veteran Crew Leader.

Deployment Zones

Crews set up in opposite corners either on the trail or in the woods inside a 4" x 4" square.

Turn Limit

Seven.

Zone Hostiles

Mission Objective: Five Bandits already visible: four Rookies lead by a Hardened Boss. 1 and 2 Actions per Activation, respectively. All of them are armed with

AKs, wearing Commercial/Civilian Armor, and each are equipped with a single Med-Kit and a Molotov Cocktail. The Bandits start in Cover and on Alert Actions. Place models and tokens appropriately. With Big Nikolai and his men present and visible, the Mission Objective is considered already Triggered. Roll as needed on the Threat Level 1 Zone Hostile Table for occupants of the two secondary Hot Spots (see page 41).

Salvage

Successful Search Action of Big Nikolai's camp after it is cleared yields one worn but very official looking keycard for an office building in the town of Ishikhov, a Molotov Cocktail, and two rolls on the Basic Equipment table (see page 32).

Secondary Hot Spots yield Salvage per appropriate Hot Spot Salvage Tables.

Game Three: The Ishikhov Shuffle

The town of Ishikhov used to be the regional administration center. Just off Highway 109 and Route 7, it was close to the military base, the refinery, and the mine. Soldiers, workers, clerks all made their home there. It had apartments, row houses, shops, nice roads, parks... even a supermarket.

It was wiped out in the first Incident and the inhabitants were killed instantly.

All those families and stores, most people believe there's plenty of regular supplies and salvage still there, lying all over the place. But everybody in the Zone seems to know a guy who went looking for easy pickings and never came back.

Word now is the place is haunted. That much death so sudden, some say it's cursed. A few of the old-timers insist the original citizens of Ishikhov are still there, lurking in the ruins of their former homes.

You're going to find out one way or another because the keycard says 'Basement 2. Central Planning Office'. The Central Planning Office (CPO) is a big, ugly concrete and steel building, built like a fortress, full of narrow halls and tiny cubicle offices. It stands dead center in the town of Ishikhov.

And that's where you're going.

Table Size

4' x 4'

Threat Level

Two – Yellow Zone. One Mission Objective. Four Hot Spots.

Terrain

The mission area is a deserted town filled with ruined homes and buildings. Two streets run North to South and two streets run East to West. These divide the table into nine sections roughly equal in size. Place the largest building in the center section and arrange other buildings and scatter terrain as desired in the remaining areas. Place one of the Secondary Hot Spots in each of the four table quadrants. These should be centered and accessible, and cannot be within 6" of the table edge or another Hot Spot.

Suggested Crew Experience

Reinforced Starter Crew with Veteran Crew Leader.

Deployment Zones

Crews set up in opposite edges of the mission area anywhere up to 4" from the edge.

Turn Limit

Seven.

Zone Hostiles

Turns out the old-timers were right all along. Place four zombie models at each of the four road intersections. These zombies activate as a single mob and will move toward and attack the closest player model in line of sight. If no player models are visible, they will move toward the CPO. They will only stop converging if a player model appears. At TL 2, they have two Actions per Activation.

These are additional Zone Hostiles not connected to the present Mission Objective or secondary Hot Spots. Roll as needed on the Threat Level 2 Zone Hostile Table to determine the occupants of the four Hot Spots (see page 41).

Salvage

After the CPO is cleared, the crew can 'enter' the building. A successful Search Action will yield 2,500 ZS worth of Salvage plus two rolls on each of the Basic, Advanced, and Special Item Equipment Tables.

Secondary Hot Spots yield Salvage per appropriate Hot Spot Salvage Tables.

Aftermath

Well done, comrade. Your first run. You put down some Zone scum, got a few notches on your AK, picked up some new gear, a new recruit maybe. Even set aside some in your Retirement fund. It's like you were made for this place. You belong here.

But a word of advice: you really want to hit it big, you need to collect Artifacts – that's where the real money is. And those are only found deep in the Zone. That's where you really want to go.

Part 11: The Last Bit

You're in the Zone now. There are enemies, rivals, horrors and mysteries waiting in the fog-shrouded, irradiated wilds. And treasure, treasure beyond your wildest imagination. It'll be terrifying, brutal, bloody and immensely rewarding – if you survive.

Zona Alfa was ordered around the simple thought that the rules shouldn't interfere with the game. They should support rather than suffocate. They should minimize friction and streamline gameplay, not bog players down in complex record-keeping, gimmicky or tedious combat mechanics. And you definitely should not have to constantly flip pages back and forth to get through a turn.

Hopefully, these rules are robust, reliable, and easy to operate. They won't cover any and every potential in-game situation, so if you encounter something during a mission, roll dice to resolve the problem, keep playing, and discuss the specific instance afterwards. I'm confident players can come up with a solid solution in keeping with the core rules and the spirit of the game.

Which is what it's all about: the story that unfolds on the table as you and your rivals advance your Crews toward the Mission Objective, never quite knowing what terrors and treasures the Zone is holding for you there.